

1974 年巴菲特致股东的信

翻译: Rick http://blog.sina.com.cn/s/blog_a3453d2201015tjr.html

To the Stockholders of Berkshire Hathaway Inc.:

Operating results for 1974 overall were unsatisfactory due to the poor performance of our insurance business. In last year's annual report some decline in profitability was predicted but the extent of this decline, which accelerated during the year, was a surprise. Operating earnings for 1974 were \$8,383,576, or \$8.56 per share, for a return on beginning shareholders' equity of 10.3%. This is the lowest return on equity realized since 1970. Our textile division and our bank both performed very well, turning in improved results against the already good figures of 1973.

致伯克希尔股东:

1974 年我们的经营业绩并不令人满意, 原因是保险业务的表现很糟。在去年的年报里, 我们曾经预测保险业务的利润率会出现下降, 但是今年下降的程度, 还是超过我们的想象。1974 年的经营利润是 838 万美元, 约合每股 8.56 美元, 以年初股东权益为基数计算的 ROE 为 10.3%。这是自 1970 年以来的最低回报。我们的纺织业务和银行业务的业绩在 1974 年表现得非常好, 在 1973 年已经不错的业绩基础上又进了一步。

However, insurance underwriting, which has been mentioned in the last several annual reports as running at levels of unsustainable profitability, turned dramatically worse as the year progressed. The outlook for 1975 is not encouraging.

然而, 对于承保业务, 我们去年的年报里已经提到利润率很低, 处于一个不可维持的水平, 但是今年的情况变得更糟。1975 年的前景也不妙。

We undoubtedly will have sharply negative comparisons in our textile operation and probably a moderate decline in banking earnings. Insurance underwriting is a large question mark at this time—it certainly won't be a satisfactory year in this area, and could be an extremely poor one. Prospects are reasonably good for an improvement in both insurance investment income and our equity in earnings of Blue Chip Stamps. During this period we plan to continue to build financial strength and liquidity, preparing for the time when insurance rates become adequate and we can once again aggressively pursue opportunities for growth in this area.

对于我们的纺织业务来说, 未来的盈利情况毫无疑问地会变差。对于我们的银行业务而言, 未来利润率可能会温和地下降。但是, 承保业务目前是一个很大的问题, 今年的经营业绩肯定不会令人满意, 而且可能会是一个很差的年份。但是保险投资收益以及蓝带印花公司的盈利前景还是不错的。在目前这个阶段, 我们将

加强我们在财务上的实力和流动性，等待时机。总有一天，承保的费率将会上升，那又将是我們大举扩张的好时候。

Textile Operations

During the first nine months of 1974 textile demand was exceptionally strong, resulting in very firm prices. However, in the fourth quarter significant weaknesses began to appear, which have continued into 1975. We currently are operating at about one-third of capacity. Obviously, at such levels operating losses must result. As shipments have fallen, we continuously have adjusted our level of operations downward so as to avoid building inventory. Our products are largely in the curtain goods area. During a period of consumer uncertainty, curtains may well be high on the list of deferrable purchases. Very low levels of housing starts also serve to dampen demand. In addition, retailers have been pressing to cut inventories generally, and we probably are feeling some effect from these efforts. These negative trends should reverse in due course, and we are attempting to minimize losses until that time comes.

纺织业务

在 1974 年的前三个季度，纺织业的需求非常强劲，产品的价格也很坚挺。但是从第四季度开始，需求出现疲软，并且这种情况一直持续到 1975 年。我们目前的产能利用率只有 1/3。很明显，在目前的产能利用率水平下，我们的运营肯定产生亏损。由于出货量的下降，我们不断地调整我们的产能以免积压大量的产成品库存。我们的产品主要用来制作窗帘。在消费不确定的时期，窗帘将位于消费者延迟购买产品名单的前列。最近新房开工量水平也很低，这将打击对窗帘的需求，雪上加霜。除此之外，零售商也在降低他们库存水平，我们目前已经对此有所感受。在适当的时候，上述的情况会逆转，但是在此之前，我们尽量将损失降到最低。

Insurance Underwriting

In the last few years we consistently have commented on the unusual profitability in insurance underwriting. This seemed certain eventually to attract unintelligent competition with consequent inadequate rates. It also has been apparent that many insurance organizations, major as well as minor, have been guilty of significant underreserving of losses, which inevitably produces faulty information as to the true cost of the product being sold.

承保业务

在过去的几年里，我们一直提到承保业务的非凡盈利能力。高盈利水平最终肯定会吸引不明智的竞争者进入，他们会将保费费率降低到亏损的水平。很明显，很多保险机构，无论大的或者小的，提取的损失准备严重不足，这真是犯罪。提取不足的损失准备不可避免地传导出关于所销售保险产品的成本的错误信息。

In 1974, these factors, along with a high rate of inflation, combined to produce a rapid erosion in underwriting results. The costs of the product we deliver (auto repair, medical payments, compensation benefits, etc.) are increasing at a rate we estimate to be in the area of 1% per month. Of course, this increase doesn't proceed in an even flow but, inexorably, inflation grinds very heavily at the repair services—to humans and to property—that we provide. However, rates virtually have been unchanged in the property and casualty field for the last few years. With costs moving forward rapidly and prices remaining unchanged, it was not hard to predict what would happen to profit margins.

在 1974 年，上述因素，再加上高通货膨胀率，对承保业务的利润是一个巨大的侵蚀。根据我们的统计，我们所销售产品的成本大约每月以 1% 的速度上涨，这些成本包括汽车维修费、医疗费用以及补偿费用。当然，不同保险领域成本的上涨幅度并不相同，但是无情地是，通货膨胀对所有维修服务的成本造成巨大的压力，不管是对人的维修（医疗保险）还是对财产的维修。然而，在过去的几年里，无论是财产保险还是人身事故保险的保费费率却一直维持不变。在成本快速上涨而产品价格保持不变的行业，不难预测利润率将如何变化。

Best's, the authoritative voice of the insurance industry, estimates that in 1974 all auto insurance premiums in the United States increased only about 2%. Such a growth in the pool of dollars available to pay insured losses and expenses was woefully inadequate. Obviously, medical costs applicable to people injured during the year, jury awards for pain and suffering, and body shop charges for repairing damaged cars increased at a dramatically greater rate during the year. Since premiums represent the sales dollar and the latter items represent the cost of goods sold, profit margins turned sharply negative.

保险行业的官方喉舌，Best's，估计 1974 年全美的汽车保险保费收入仅增长 2%。靠这样一个增长率来支付投保人的损失和保险公司的费用是远远不够的。一个明显的事实是：1974 年，在汽车事故中受伤人员的医疗费用、法院判给汽车事故受害人的赔偿以及受损汽车的维修费用大幅上升。保费是保险公司的收入，而后面这 3 项费用是保险公司销售产品的成本，承保利润率已经大幅下降为负。

As this report is being written, such deterioration continues. Loss reserves for many giant companies still appear to be understated by significant amounts, which means that these competitors continue to underestimate their true costs. Not only must rates be increased sufficiently to match the month-by-month increase in cost levels, but the existed expense- revenue gap must be overcome. At this time it appears that insurers must experience even more devastating underwriting results before they take appropriate pricing action.

我在写这篇报告的时候，这样的恶化还在继续。许多大型保险公司的损失准备依然严重提取不足，这意味着我们的竞争对手仍然低估他们真实的承保成本。现在，承保费率需要大幅上升，这样做不仅是为了弥补逐月不断上涨的承保成本，还需要弥补业已存在的保费收入和费用之间的差额。以目前的时点来看，保险行业还需要经历更坏的经营业绩，保险公司才会开始采取行动提高保费费率。

All major areas of insurance operations, except for the "home state" companies, experienced significantly poorer results for the year. The direct business of National Indemnity Company, our largest area of insurance activity, produced an underwriting loss of approximately 4% after several years of high profitability. Volume increased somewhat, but we are not encouraging such increases until rates are more adequate.

伯克希尔所有的保险业务实体，除了我们自己开始的保险公司以外，在 1974 年都经历了经营业绩的大幅下滑。我们在保险领域最大的经营实体，国民赔偿公司，在经历了几年高利润率之后，1974 年的承保利润率大约为-4%。该公司的保费收入有所增长，但是我们并不鼓励这样的增长，除非保费费率提升到足够高。

At some point in the cycle, after major insurance companies have had their fill of red ink, history indicates that we will experience an inflow of business at compensatory rates. This operation, headed by Phil Liesche, a most able underwriter, is staffed by highly profit-oriented people and we believe it will provide excellent earnings in most future years, as it has in the past.

在保险行业周期里的某个时点，在主要的大型保险公司都经历了亏损之后，历史经验表明我们又将迎来一次补偿性的大幅增长。由 Phil 带领的（国民赔偿公司）保险业务团队，里面都是利润导向的员工，我们相信他们在未来的大多数年份里都会取得优异的成绩，就像过去那样。

Intense competition in the reinsurance business has produced major losses for practically every company operating in the area. We have been no exception. Our underwriting loss was something over 12%—a horrendous figure, but probably little different from the average of the industry. What is even more frightening is that, while about the usual number of insurance catastrophes occurred during 1974, there really was no "super disaster" which might have accounted for the poor figures of the industry.

再保险领域竞争激烈，1974 年这个行业的每个公司都产生了巨大亏损。我们也不例外。我们的承保利润率为-12%，这是一个令人恐怖的数字，但是离行业的

平均水平不远。更令人担心的是：1974 年发生的大灾难的数量并没有偏离正常水平，再保险业务的承保业绩这么差，并没有超级大灾难可以被拿来做解释。

Rather, a condition of inadequate rates prevails, particularly in the casualty area where we have significant exposure. Our reinsurance department is run by George Young, an exceptionally competent and hardworking manager. He has cancelled a great many contracts where prices are totally inadequate, and is making no attempt to increase volume except in areas where premiums are commensurate with risk. Based upon present rate levels, it seems highly unlikely that the reinsurance industry generally, or we, specifically, will have a profitable year in 1975.

然而，行业内保费费率严重偏低，特别是在我们有巨大风险敞口的意外伤害保险领域。我们的再保险团队由杨乔治领导，他能力超强，工作努力。他取消了很多合同，这些合同的保费费率是偏低的；同时他并不想增加保费收入，除非保费收入与风险是匹配的。在目前的保费费率水平下，整个再保险行业，包括我们，在 1975 年想要盈利基本不可能。

Our "home state" companies, under the leadership of John Ringwalt, made good progress in 1974. We appear to be developing a sound agency group, capable of producing business with acceptable loss ratios. Our expense ratios still are much too high, but will come down as the operation develops into units of economic size. The Texas problem which was commented upon in last year's report seems to be improving. We consider the "home state" operation one of our most promising areas for the future.

我们在本州（内布拉斯加州）自己经营的保险公司，在 John Ringwalt 的领导下，在 1974 年取得了较好的进展。我们培养出了一个扎实的保险代理人队伍，能够代理保费收入并将承保损失控制在可接受的范围之内。我们的成本率还是比较高，但是随着我们业务规模的扩大，这个比率会降下来。我们在去年的年报里提到的德州的问题今年更严重。我们认为本州的业务是我们未来几个前途光明的业务之一。

Our efforts to expand Home and Automobile Insurance Company into Florida proved disastrous. The underwriting loss from operations in that market will come to over \$2 million, a very large portion of which was realized in 1974. We made the decision to drop out of the Florida market in the middle of 1974, but losses in substantial amounts have continued since that time because of the term nature of insurance contracts, as well as adverse development of outstanding claims. We can't blame external insurance industry conditions for this mistake. In retrospect, it is apparent that our management simply did not have the underwriting information and the pricing knowledge necessary to be operating in the area.

家庭汽车保险公司将其业务扩展到佛罗里达州真是一场灾难。在这个市场的承保损失将超过 2 百万美元，大部分损失在 1974 年实现。我们在 1974 年中期做出决定：退出佛罗里达州。但是由于保险合同的期限原因，我们还会产生大量的损失，同时索赔的情况也将继续恶化。在佛州的错误我们不能责怪市场。相反，这是我们管理团队对该地区的承保信息掌握不足，保险定价知识缺乏的体现。（巴菲特在 1971 年和 1972 年的年报里赞美该公司的高管，而 1973 年的年报里就不提了。在 1974 年的年报里，则言辞激烈地批评该公司的高管，rick）。

In Cook County, where Home and Auto's volume traditionally has been concentrated, evidence also became quite clear during 1974 that rates were inadequate. Therefore, rates were increased during the middle of the year but competition did not follow; consequently, our volume has dropped significantly in this area as competitors take business from us at prices that we regard as totally unrealistic.

在家庭汽车保险公司业务主要的集中地，库克县，情形已经越来越明朗：承保费率不足（以覆盖承保成本和公司运营费用）。因此，我们在 1974 年的年中提价，但是我们的竞争对手并没有跟随。结果就是，我们在库克县的保费收入大幅下滑，我们的竞争对手用一个我们认为是荒唐的价格抢走了我们的生意。

While the tone of this section is pessimistic as to 1974 and 1975, we consider the insurance business to be inherently attractive.

在 1974 年和 1975 年，保险业务的主基调是悲观的。但是从本质上来讲，保险业务还是有吸引力的。

Our overall return on capital employed in this area—even including the poor results of 1974—remains high. We have made every effort to be realistic in the calculation of loss and administrative expense.

我们在保险领域的投入资本回报率（即使考虑了 1974 年的糟糕业绩），还是很高的。我们在计算承保损失和公司运营费用的时候努力保持客观，符合实际情况。

（这里我们找到的英文原文可能有所遗漏，因为上下文并不衔接。）

Because of accruals, this had a double effect at both the bank and corporate level in 1974. Under present money market conditions, we expect bank earnings to be down somewhat in 1975 although we believe they still are likely to compare favorably with those of practically any banking institution in the country.

因为会计上的应计制，将对银行层面和公司层面都造成影响（这句话在这里不知何意？可能是因为原文有所遗漏 rick）。在目前的货币市场条件下，我们预期银行的盈利在 1975 年出现些许下降，但还我们仍然相信，和美国其他任何银行相比，伊州国民银行的业绩表现将会相当不错。

Blue Chip Stamps

During 1974 we increased our holdings of Blue Chip Stamps to approximately 25.5% of the outstanding shares of that company. Overall, we are quite happy about the results of Blue Chip and its prospects for the future. Stamp sales continue at a greatly reduced level, but the Blue Chip management has done an excellent job of adjusting operating costs. The See's Candy Shops, Inc. subsidiary had an outstanding year, and has excellent prospects for the future. Your Chairman is on the Board of Directors of Blue Chip Stamps, as well as Wesco Financial Corporation, a 64% owned subsidiary, and is Chairman of the Board of See's Candy Shops, Inc. We expect Blue Chip Stamps to be a source of continued substantial earning power for Berkshire Hathaway Inc.

蓝带印花公司

在 1974 年，我们把我们对蓝带印花公司的持股比例提高到 25.5%。我们对蓝带印花公司的经营情况非常满意，对其前景充满信心。印花纸带的销售继续大幅下降，公司的管理层在调整运营成本方面工作出色。蓝带印花公司的子公司，喜诗糖果今年的业绩很好，前景更好。你们的主席是蓝带印花公司的董事，也是 wesco 金融公司的董事（蓝带印花公司持有 Wesco 64% 的股份），同时是喜诗糖果的董事会主席。我们期待蓝带印花公司成为伯克希尔持续盈利能力超强的业务中的一份子。

The annual report of Blue Chip Stamps, which will contain financial statements for the year ended March 1, 1975 audited by Price, Waterhouse and Company, will be available in May. Any shareholder of Berkshire Hathaway Inc. who desires an annual report of Blue Chip Stamps may obtain it at any time by writing Mr. Robert H. Bird, Secretary, Blue Chip Stamps, 5801 South Eastern Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90040.

在 5 月初，我们就可以提供蓝带印花公司的年报了。年报里有其财务报表的数据，最近年度的财报截止日期为 1975 年 3 月 1 日，审计师为普华永道。伯克希尔的股东如果想要看蓝带印花公司的年报可以在任何时间写信给公司的秘书伯德先生。公司的地址是：Blue Chip Stamps, 5801 South Eastern Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90040.

Merger with Diversified Retailing Company, Inc.

As you previously have been informed, the proposed merger with Diversified Retailing Company, Inc. was terminated by the respective Boards of Directors on January 28, 1975. We continue to view such a merger as eventually desirable, and hope to reopen the subject at some future time.

与多元零售公司的合并

就像曾经告诉过你们的那样，伯克希尔与多元零售公司的合并于 1975 年 1 月 28 日中止了。我们仍然认为最终这两个公司是有可能合并的，我们希望在未来某个时候再重新讨论这个话题。

Warren E. Buffett

Chairman of the Board

March 31, 1975